

How to brief an instructional designer without ending up with a three-month rebuild

Most compliance and onboarding training gets built two ways: an off-the-shelf course that half-fits, or a bespoke build that drags on because nobody was clear on scope from day one. This is the checklist that keeps you out of the second one.

01 · RAW MATERIAL

What you already have

- ☐ Every document in one place.
Scripts, SOPs, slide decks, old course exports, gathered into a single folder, not scattered across three drives and someone's inbox.
- ☐ Regulatory or compliance requirements named explicitly.
Written down, not assumed to be "obvious" to whoever builds it.

02 · THE KNOWLEDGE THAT ISN'T WRITTEN DOWN

What's still in someone's head

- ☐ 20 to 30 minutes recorded with whoever actually does this work.
Talking it through in their own words. A recording catches the "everyone here already knows that" gaps a written brief always misses.
- ☐ A named contact for follow-up questions.
Not just at kickoff, through the build. The gaps in a brief usually surface in week two.

03 · WHAT "DONE" ACTUALLY LOOKS LIKE

The technical detail people forget to confirm

- ☐ Platform and standard confirmed, not guessed.
LMS name, and whether it needs SCORM 1.2, SCORM 2004, or xAPI.
- ☐ Pass mark, completion tracking and certification requirements written down.
If this needs to prove someone did it, that proof has to be specified up front.
- ☐ Whether it needs to run standalone in a browser as well as inside the LMS.

04 · SCOPE AND SHAPE

What you're actually asking for

- ☐ Roughly how many hours of learning time.
And whether this is one course, or the first of a growing library that needs a consistent format.
- ☐ Who the learner actually is.
Their role, reading level, and how much time they'll realistically give it. A field crew and a finance team don't learn the same way.
- ☐ One example of tone you like, one you don't.
"Professional" means nothing on its own, show, don't describe.

05 · BEFORE YOU SIGN ANYTHING

The two lines that prevent most disputes

- ☐ A fixed number of revision rounds, agreed up front.
- ☐ Who owns the source files when it's finished.
So the content is never locked to one vendor or one licence.

Digital Technology Training

Compliance and onboarding eLearning for regulated industries. Articulate Storyline, Rise 360, HTML/JS. SCORM and xAPI, built to your brief, not a template. · packager.dtttech.com · michael@dttech.com